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PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES

OFFICIAL REPORT

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THE
PARLIAMENT OF THE REPUBLIC
OF GHANA

THIRD MEETING, 2025

Thursday, 30th October, 2025

*The House met at the Chamber,
Parliament House, at 3:28 p.m.*

[THE SPEAKER, RT HON ALBAN
SUMANA KINGSFORD BAGBIN, IN
THE CHAIR]

[PRAYERS]

The Speaker: Hon Members, we would move straight to the item numbered 5, *Correction of Votes and Proceedings* and the *Official Report*.

We would start with the *Votes and Proceedings* of Wednesday, 29th October, 2025—Sorry.

Yes, Hon Habib Iddrisu?

First Deputy Minority Whip (Alhaji Habib Iddrisu): Mr Speaker, thank you.

Mr Speaker, I want to draw your attention to Article 102 of the 1992 Constitution. With your permission, I read;

“A quorum of Parliament, apart from the person presiding, shall be one-third of all the Members of Parliament present”.

Mr Speaker, looking at the House, we are 276, and one-third of 276 is 92. We are only 70 in the Chamber. For that matter, I urge you to apply the rules, that

we do not have quorum to continue with this Sitting as stated in Article 102 of the 1992 Constitution.

Mr Speaker, I so pray that the right thing is done.

Yesterday, you cautioned all of us and the media houses carried it, that if we are not serious to continue Business, we should not let Ghanaians think same and at the moment, out of 276, we are only 70 in the Chamber.

Mr Speaker, I urge you to apply the rules as stated in Article 102 of the 1992 Constitution.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Suhuyini Sayibu Alhassan?

Alhaji Suhuyini Sayibu Alhassan: Mr Speaker, I rise not to challenge the appeal that has been made by my Hon Brother, the Member of Parliament for Tolon, except to say that, I think that it is a huge indictment on the Leadership of the House, especially my Hon Brother, who is also the Deputy Whip of the Minority Side. When I look on their Side, I do not see their Members present —
[Uproar]

Mr Speaker, the perks that they enjoy as Leaders are to ensure that they also, especially as Whips, ensure that their Members are present. Mr Speaker, this House is not made up of only Majority Members of Parliament. This House is made up of two political parties, and we expect that our numbers be present, but we also expect that the Minority that have also been voted to represent their constituents are marshalled to be in the House.

Mr Speaker, I am disappointed in the leadership of the Whip that he is not able to whip his Side to be on the Floor, and he is advertising it the way he is doing.

Thank you very much. [*Uproar*]

The Speaker: Let me first listen to the Hon Member for Damongo before I come to the Majority Chief Whip.

Mr Samuel Abdulai Jinapor: Mr Speaker, thank you very much.

Mr Speaker, yesterday we were all in this Chamber and you had reason to admonish all of us to take our duties as Members of Parliament seriously. The Deputy Minority Whip alluded to that, and indeed, it has been widely covered by the media. Mr Speaker, even went to the extent of publishing the names of 28 people who have missed Parliament for a certain number of days.

Mr Speaker, I think it is important for us to make two fundamental points. The first one, the composition of this Parliament is a very special one, and it has never happened in the history of our country.

3:38p.m.

Mr Speaker, for the first time in the Fourth Republic, we have a Parliament where a particular group has a super Majority. They have two thirds; it has never happened in the Fourth Republican dispensation before. Of the 276 Hon Members of Parliament, the Majority which is the National Democratic Congress (NDC) Side, has 189 Hon Members of Parliament. Mr Speaker,

you are as old as this legislature, it has never happened before.

Secondly, this House mostly deals with Government Business, and that is why the Hon Majority Leader is mostly referred to as the Leader of Government Business. Throughout this Session of Parliament, the First Meeting, the Second Meeting and the Third Meeting, our Friends, all the 189 of them from the other Side, consistently do not attend to the House.

In fact, Mr Speaker, the NDC Side, which is the Majority Side, can: one, form quorum on their own; two, have enough Hon Members of Parliament to conduct Business; and three, they can have enough Hon Members of Parliament to take most fundamental decisions, and yet, they do not come to Parliament. [*Uproar*]

Mr Speaker, I have in my hand, the *Order Paper* for 30th October, 2025, and in this *Order Paper*, we have so many important Government Businesses listed to be taken today. If you would allow me to point out some of them: there are Papers to be laid; the Scholarship Scheme of our country, where the welfare of students is to be discussed here in this House, and yet they do not come to Parliament; 189 of them, the super Majority, two-thirds of Parliament. They say we are micro-Minority, and yet they cannot carry Government Business through.

Mr Speaker, I want to conclude by submitting that Ghanaians queued and stood under the sun on 7th December. Ghanaians gave them an extraordinary

mandate; Ghanaians gave them 189 Hon Members of Parliament because they wanted the Business of President Mahama and agenda to go through in this House without any hindrance. And yet, they cannot produce 90 Hon Members out of the 189 Hon Members to form quorum for us to proceed to conduct Business in this House.

Mr Speaker, with the greatest respect, this Majority, the 189 of them, their quantity—I want to conclude by saying that this is an absent super Majority; an absent 189 Majority. They can do better, and they should feel embarrassed, not us. Thank you, Mr Speaker. *[Hear! Hear!]*

The Speaker: Yes, Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, respectfully, your attention has been drawn to an alleged absence of quorum in pursuance of Order 64 (3).

Mr Speaker, the Hon Member in drawing your attention referenced Article 102 of the Constitution *simpliciter*. But Article 102 is given effect in Order 64 of our Standing Orders, particularly Order 64(3). What the Hon Member did is in consonance with that. But then, it gives us the opportunity to ascertain the veracity of the basis for raising the matter within the premise of Article 102. Mr Speaker, with your leave I read Order 64 (3):

“A Member may draw the attention of the person presiding at any time during a sitting...”

[Interruption]

Mr Speaker, I listened to them in silence, so, they should listen to me in silence.

Mr Speaker, the Order further says:

“...that Members present in the House, constitute less than one-third of the number of all the Members of Parliament.”

So, we raised an issue about a commencement quorum.

Mr Speaker, Order 64 (4) says, and with your leave, I read:

“The person presiding shall

- (a) direct the Clerks-at-the-Table to cause the bell to be rang;
- (b) continue the business of the House for a period of ten minutes;
- (c) direct the Clerks-at-the-Table to conduct a headcount of members present; and
- (d) if there is still no quorum, suspend the sitting of the House for a period of no more than one hour.”

[Interruption]

Please, let us stop this. Mr Speaker, the Hon Member is seeking to do a propaganda with this matter, but we will set this matter within the law.

Mr Speaker, Order 64 (5) says, and with your leave, I read:

“If on resumption of the Stting there is still no quorum upon the conduct of a headcount, the House shall stand adjourned till the next sitting day without Question being put.”

Mr Speaker, instead of my Brother, Mr Samuel Abdulai Jinapor, to make these arguments within the premise of the law, he decides to do a propaganda. Yesterday, we conducted Government Business on this Floor. *[Interruption]*

Please, the *Votes and Proceedings* is the evidence of what happened. Yesterday, there were 176 Hon Members of this House. The records will bear us out. So, the propaganda, that the mighty Majority are absent, is not borne out by the records. So, when issues are raised—These are matters of procedure. We cannot sidestep the procedure and do otherwise.

It is good the Hon Member proceeded within Order 64(3). He has drawn your attention to an alleged absence of the adequate numbers for a commencement quorum. The law provides what should be done. I believe the Rt Hon Speaker will direct the Clerks-at-the-Table to ring the bell, the numbers will increase and we will proceed.

Mr Speaker, having said this, I believe that yesterday, you had cause to encourage Hon Members to attend upon the House at 2 p.m. Before we adjourned, the records will bear me out that I drew

the attention of the leadership of Committees. We have discovered that leaders of Committees arrange Committee Business in the afternoon when we have all agreed that Committee Businesses should be arranged in the morning, so that when it is 2 p.m., we will be ready to conduct Business at Plenary.

Mr Speaker, the *Order Paper* for today again shows that there are advertised meetings of Committees for the afternoon when we had encouraged them to shift the afternoon meetings of Committees to the morning so that in the afternoon, we will have adequate numbers at Plenary.

So, Mr Speaker, we would implore the leaders of Committees, that is the Chairpersons and Ranking Members to arrange Committee Businesses from about 9 a.m. up to about midday, so that by 1 p.m., we will be ready to start Business at 2 p.m. We are depleted because of the Committee Sittings.

3:48 p.m.

As we speak, the Committee on Public Administration and State Interests and other Committees are sitting. The Public Accounts Committee and the Committee on Information and Communications also sat.

So, Mr Speaker, Committee numbers on an average consist of about 24 Members. So, if we have three Committees sitting, that is in excess of 75. We encourage the Committee members to conduct Business in the morning, so that in the afternoons, we will be ready. But I can assure my

Brother that we have the numbers to start Business. The bell has been rung, and they will be here.

Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity.

The Speaker: Hon Members, I thought you had permitted me to give effect to our Standing Orders by directing the Clerks-at-the-Table to cause the bell to be rung. It was very obvious when we started that the numbers actually fell far below a quorum, and our rules are clear on that. So, I directed that the bell be rung, and the rule gives us only 10 minutes to proceed. If you actually meant what you were doing, you should have allowed this to take place. And by this time, the 10 minutes would have been gone. But knowing your Business, you continued your usual way.

So, please, Clerks-at-the-Table, cause the bell to be rung. Then we will continue with the Business. I have my timer here, and when it is 10 minutes, we will count to see what number we have on the Floor. And that will determine whether we adjourn or continue with Business. I so direct.

Hon Members, in the meantime, you can see our gallery is full. We have a number of visitors with us. The first group, I am told, is from the Youth Empowerment Consortium. They are being led by one of my colleagues, who is referred to as “Speaker”. So, I have a colleague here at the Visitor’s Gallery leading the delegation from the Youth Empowerment Consortium. The leader

of the group is Adam Suhuyini Salifu. We have as many as 135 of them present here.

Let me warmly welcome them to the Parliament of Ghana, particularly our Plenary session, and encourage them to continue to visit us from time to time. Today, you just had a bit of a taste of what happens here. Whether what you hear on the radio or see on Television is what actually happens here, you have experienced it yourself. So, it is our pleasure to have you, and we believe that in the future you will surmount all the challenges this current generation is facing. You may resume your seats.

[Representatives of the Youth Empowerment Consortium were acknowledged.]

The Speaker: We have another delegation from Asikuma/Odoben/Brakwa Constituency. That is the Constituency we call AOB, ‘any other business’ —*[Laughter]*— The group is led by the head teacher, and they are from Brakwa Methodist Basic School. The name of the head teacher is Abigail Jane Sam. I think that should be headmistress. Yes, you are most welcome.

Sorry, we kept you all waiting because we were trying to manage a few things behind the scenes. This is your Parliament. You are welcome anytime, and we want to encourage you to continue to do this. We thank you for bringing all these students to observe what happens here. You may resume your seats. They are 55 in number. That is a lot of cost.

[Pupils of the Brakwa Methodist Basic School were acknowledged.]

The Speaker: The third group comes from all over the country, and they are the winners of the 2025 National Public Speaking Competition, which is usually organised by DeeDee Global.

I am one of the patrons of this competition, and annually, for and on your behalf, we have been supporting the competition. They came today to receive their prizes, and for us to think over it. I need to, on your behalf, congratulate the organisers of this competition. They are quite forceful and put a lot of pressure on me each year; I saw two of them again today.

They are being led by their coordinator, Bertha Amanor. They are 40 in number, and so we just finished having the session with them at the Justice D.F. Annan Auditorium and they came to me to make the presentation. That took a bit of our time. You are most welcome and you are learning better than us. Because that is the journey you are already going through; advocacy; how to speak in public. And I can say that these young guys up there are very excellent and can beat a lot of us here, including myself. So, congratulations. Please, you may resume your seats.

[Representatives of the National Public Speaking Competition were acknowledged.]

3:58 p.m.

The Speaker: We have the last group coming from Kpone Katamanso. They are 64 in number and are coming

from the East Bank School Complex. They are led by their teacher, Adriana Sam. You are also welcome, and we encourage you to come more. These are rather a younger breed and it is good to catch them young. Please kindly resume your seats.

[Pupils of the East Bank School Complex were acknowledged.]

Hon Members, it is even more than 10 minutes now. I think we will take a count to see whether we now have a quorum. Please, Clerk-at-the-Table, do so now.

[Pause]

Hon Members, please, stop the movement. It is making it difficult for us to take the count.

[Pause]

Hon Members, the Clerk has submitted a number to me after taking the count, and the number I have here is 103. *[Uproar]*

Hon Member, we have quorum to proceed with the Business of the House. *[Hear! Hear!]*

I accordingly proceed to take item 6 on the *Order Paper*.

Yes, Leadership?

Majority Leader (Mr Mahama Ayariga): Mr Speaker, the Minister for Transport and the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs are here. So, Mr Speaker, we are

ready of all the Questions to be asked today.

The Speaker: Hon Member, we will start with the Urgent Question which stands in the name of the Hon Member for Pru East, Mr Emmanuel Kwaku Boam.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I think the Hon Majority Leader is moving fast and I want your guidance. We did not do item numbered 5, correction of *Votes and Proceedings* and the *Official Report* and we are already moving to item numbered 6. I have not heard any variation in the order of Business.

The Speaker: Hon Member, thank you for reminding us. We did not complete the correction of *Votes and Proceedings* and this issue was raised because of the nature of our Standing Orders. So, you are right. We will have to complete the correction of *Votes and Proceedings*.

VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND THE OFFICIAL REPORT

The Speaker: I think I just started page 1, and he had to raise the lack of quorum. Now that we have the quorum, we will continue.

Page 1...7—

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, let me help my Colleague. On page 7, item 70, the Hon Minister, Dr Abdul-Rashid Hassan Pelpuo was in the Chamber yesterday during the Consideration

Stage of the Ghana Scholarships Authority Bill, 2025. I think he even made contributions to that, but he has been captured as absent. I think he was in the Chamber yesterday.

The Speaker: Is the Hon Member around?

Majority Chief Whip (Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor): Mr Speaker, Dr Pelpuo has just stepped out, but he is in the Chamber.

The Speaker: Table, kindly take note of that.

Page 8—

Prof Kingsley Nyarko: Mr Speaker, on page 8, under item 6, Formal Communication by the Speaker, the last three words; The word 'Standing Orders' did not appear correctly. It is 'Stranding Orders', so we only have to delete the 'r' so that we have 'Standing Orders'. Thank you, Mr Speaker.

The Speaker: Table, I am sure you located the error. Kindly take note.

Page 9...10—

Mr Frank Afriyie: Mr Speaker, just a minor observation. If you look at Question 372 at page 10, the question stood in the name of the Hon Member for Akuapem North.

4.08 p.m.

The manner in which Akuapem is spelled here as compared to the next, which is Question 382, is different. For

the sake of consistency, the Clerks-at-the-Table should take note.

Thank you.

The Speaker: So, which is the correct one?

Mr Afriyie: Mr Speaker, respectfully, it is a settled debate. The Member once told us that it is the one spelt with “e” after “p”. He once told the House that, that is how the name of his Constituency is spelled.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Members, we were taught by different tutors, and we were given both spellings. In fact, there are even more. But your second point, consistency, is something that should prevail here. At least, if we are adopting one, we should adopt one with the “i” or with the “e”, or with the “w” or whatever. But here, the “w” one is not in issue. So, please, it is either we take the “e” or we take the “i”. But once the MP is insisting that it is the “e” that is the correct one, I think we should be guided by that. So, Clerks-at-the-Table, kindly take note and keep on spelling it properly as demanded by the Member of Parliament who is the authorised representative in this House.

Page 11? Yes, Hon Member?

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, on page 11 the item numbered 10, “Presentation of a Paper”. On the name of the Ministry, this current Administration changed the name from the “Ministry of Fisheries and Aquaculture Development” to “Ministry of Fisheries and Aquaculture”. There is

no “Development”. So, I will be happy if the Clerks-at-the-Table will check to be sure whether the Ministry has “Development” as part of its name or not.

Thank you.

The Speaker: Yes, Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the work of the Table Office is to capture the documents as they are titled. This is a report of 2024. In 2024, it was “Ministry of Fisheries and Aquaculture Development”. That was how come the Auditor-General’s report captured it that way. It is not a report in respect of activities from 2025. So, they cannot capture how the report is captured differently. Unless he is arguing that he has seen the report and it is not titled, “Annual Statement of the Audit Committee Ministry of Fisheries and Aquaculture Development for the year 2024”.

Prof Nyarko: My point is that looking at the sentence, “The following Paper was presented by the Hon Minister for Education, Mr Haruna Iddrisu on behalf of the Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture Development”. He did so on behalf of the Minister. I am saying that this Ministry’s name has changed, unless I am wrong. So, if Hon Haruna Iddrisu is presenting it on behalf of this Minister, it should not be on behalf of the Minister during the prior era. So, it should be “Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture”. If that is the name of the Ministry, then that is what it should be. That is my position on this.

The Speaker: Clerks-at-the-Table, kindly check whether the Ministry still has “Development” as part of its name or not, and then do the right thing.

Page 12. Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Afriyie: The item numbered 8 on page 12, Clause 25 is a stand-alone clause so it should come without the letter “s”. It should not be “Clauses”, it should be “Clause 25”.

The Speaker: Yes, the Hon Member is right. Table Office, kindly take note.

Page 13 ... 17.

Hon Members, in the absence of any further corrections, the *Votes and Proceedings* of the sixth Sitting dated Wednesday, 29th October, 2025, as corrected, is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

May we now move on to the next item, which is the item numbered 6, Urgent Questions. We have one Urgent Question, which stands in the name of the Hon Member for Pru-East, Mr Emmanuel Kwaku — I heard someone trying to correct my pronunciation “Boam”, Mr Emmanuel Kwaku Boam. You may ask your Question now.

URGENT QUESTION

MINISTRY OF TRANSPORT

Steps to Increase the Number of Ferries from Yeji to Makango

Dr Thomas Winsum Anabah on behalf of Mr Emmanuel Kwaku Boam (NDC — Pru-East): Thank you, Mr

Speaker. I rise on Order 88(3), on his express authorisation to seek permission from you to ask the Question on his behalf.

The Speaker: Hon Member, you may do so.

Dr Anabah: Thank you, Mr Speaker. I beg to ask the Minister for Transport the immediate steps the Ministry is taking to increase the number of ferries operating between Yeji and Makango, given the overwhelming demand and pressure on the existing single ferry.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Minister for Transport (Mr Joseph Nikpe Bukari): Mr Speaker, on immediate measures, the Volta Lake Transport Company has extended its operating hours where feasible to accommodate the growing traffic, prioritise efficient loading and offloading processes, to reduce turnaround time and strengthen its maintenance regime to improve vessel uptime.

Mr Speaker, the medium to long-term solution is that the Ministry of Transport continues to pursue a Korean EXIM Bank facility for the improvement of the Volta Lake Transport System. The project scope covers interventions that will revolutionise transportation and safety of the lake, including the supply of five modular ferries alongside the development of landing stages. Mr Speaker, it will also include improvement of infrastructure and this will significantly improve the reliability and efficiency of

the Volta Lake Transport Company's operation.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Member, any supplementary question?

Dr Anabah: Mr Speaker, has the Ministry conducted any assessment on the current carrying capacity of the existing ferry to determine the urgency and timelines for additional transport?

Mr Bukari: Mr Speaker, the Volta Lake is one of the travel systems we are looking at improving in order to create an integrated multimodal transport system that will take traffic from the road to the lake.

4.18 p.m.

We have done all our studies and we know all the crossing points. We are only pursuing this facility to be able to procure the needed ferries that will be distributed along the Volta Lake to improve upon connectivity.

Thank you.

The Speaker: Hon Member, any further supplementary?

Dr Anabah: Mr Speaker, yes.

In the interim, is the Ministry considering maintenance or refurbishment of the existing ferry to ensure safety and uninterrupted operations? Given the critical role of the Yendi-Makango route

in linking the Northern and Southern Trade Corridor, has the Ministry considered prioritising the Corridor as a strategic transport route?

The Speaker: Yes, Minister?

Mr Bukari: Mr Speaker, this includes the short-term measures that we are taking to improve upon our maintenance regime and also to be able to turn around the loading and offloading time. The vessel is being maintained. Because it is a single vessel, we are keeping track of it and maintaining it as it requires. We are also improving the services of our workers who handle loading, ticketing and help the vessel to navigate safely.

So, we are looking at the maintenance of it because it is a single one. We do not want to have a situation where it would break down and we would not be able to serve our people. The maintenance is something of priority to us and we are keeping to our routine maintenance.

Mr Speaker, thank you.

The Speaker: Hon Members, that is the end of the Questions referred to as Urgent Questions. We will move on to Questions generally, those that are not urgent and we have before us here their Answers.

We will take Question 321, which stands in the name of the Hon Member of Parliament for Bantama, Mr Francis Asenso-Boakye.

ORAL ANSWERS TO QUESTIONS

MINISTRY OF TRANSPORT

Measures to Revitalise Metro Mass Transit System

Mr Francis Asenso-Boakye (NPP—Bantama): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Transport what specific measures the Ministry is implementing to revitalise the Metro Mass Transit system at Abrepo Junction to improve efficiency, enhance commuters' accessibility in the Ashanti Region and create employment opportunities for the local economy.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Minister for Transport (Mr Joseph Nikpe Bukari): Mr Speaker, the current operational fleet of Metro Mass Transit Limited (MMTL), comprising approximately 134 buses, presents significant challenges in sustaining operational costs and expanding services. For this reason, MMTL is implementing measures to renew the fleet, modernise, and expand terminal facilities to enhance service and create employment opportunities.

Mr Speaker, I wish to inform the House that the Company is in the process of acquiring about 500 new buses over the short to medium term to augment its operations. These buses will be deployed within the country to optimise existing routes and establish new routes in underserved areas with which Abrepo Junction will be part.

The Company is also taking steps to implement a 24-Hour Economy service. This will begin with the vehicle maintenance department and the Traffic Unit to ensure buses are available round the clock. To support this, comprehensive training programmes will be provided to operational crew, ticketing staff, and related personnel to enhance service delivery and operational efficiency.

The Speaker: Hon Member, any supplementary question?

Mr Asenso-Boakye: Mr Speaker, I am excited by the announcement of the 500 new buses. Could the Hon Minister provide a specific timeline when the 500 new buses will be procured and deployed?

The Speaker: Yes, Minister?

Mr Bukari: Mr Speaker, the MMTL had challenges. From 2017, they had an operational fleet of 1,157 buses. Today, there are 134, meaning that they are in distress. For that matter, it is taking some time to be able to organise the private investors to invest in the venture. However, with the intervention of His Excellency the President, we are sure that by close of year and early next year, we will be receiving some new fleets.

Thank you.

The Speaker: Hon Minister, the Answer you published here referred to it as short to medium term. But when you were reading, you said short to long term. Maybe that is what occasioned his Question because you did not say medium

term. You are talking about short to long term. That is why he is asking for some timeline.

Now, you said that at the end of this year or early next year, we are expecting to get new buses. For that one, whether it is two or 10 or 1000, we do not know. So, we are still not guided. Please, could you clarify these issues for us?

Mr Bukari: Mr Speaker, thank you. The number of buses we are anticipating will come in batches. The 500 fleet of buses will not come at once. We are in negotiations with about three companies, and the buses will come in 50s. So, each company will supply 50 buses in turns; we are looking at acquiring 150 buses by the close of the year and early next year for us to augment our fleet.

Mr Speaker, thank you for the correction on short to medium term, but what I have on my paper is “long term”.

Thank you.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Asenso-Boakyee: Mr Speaker, I am happy that the Minister has announced that by the end of the year, the Ministry will supply 150 new buses. Given that Ashanti Region is the nodal region with very serious transportation implications, how many of these 150 buses will be allocated to Ashanti Region and the Abrepo Junction Terminal to be specific?

Thank you.

Mr Bukari: Mr Speaker, I mentioned that from 2017, we had 1,157 buses. We are now operating with 134 buses. Even if we bring in 150 buses, there would still be shortage of buses. So, I rightly said that we will distribute them within the country and Abrepo Junction will be part. But regarding the number that will go to Ashanti Region, we will look at how the traffic flows and based on the demand, we will be able to distribute accordingly. Some people do not even have, and when one looks at the transport connectivity within Ashanti Region, it may be better than some other regions that are not properly served. For us, we will evenly distribute them any time we have them in our custody.

Thank you.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Nana Agyei Baffour Awuah —
rose —

Dr Abdul Kabiru Tiah Mahama —
rose —

The Speaker: Who is senior?

Mr Baffour Awuah: Contemporary senior.

4:28 p.m.

The Speaker: You are contemporary. You were born the same day—
[Laughter]— yes, so that should be considered, since you were born earlier than him.

Mr Baffour Awuah: Mr Speaker, thank you very much. If the Hon Minister may indulge me in respect of

this question, he stated that the Metro Mass Transit Limited is in distress and so the buses will be coming by the end of the year upon the intervention of the President. I would like to find out from the Hon Minister whether the funding is provided for in the Budget and where it is captured in the Budget.

The Speaker: Hon Member, read the provision on anticipation. You are inviting the Minister to anticipate how much will be in the Budget. You are not talking about the loan facility, but how much will be in the 2026 Budget.

Mr Baffour Awuah: Mr Speaker, he stated that the buses will be coming by the end of this year; the Budget year. So, I am asking if it is captured in the Budget for 2025 and if it is captured, where in the Budget is it captured?

The Speaker: You are partly right, but he was not too specific as to when the buses will arrive. The Hon Member used the word turn of the year, but he talked about end of the year or early next year.

Mr Baffour Awuah: Mr Speaker, so in respect of those that will be coming at the end of this year, was it captured in the Budget and where in the Budget is it captured?

The Speaker: Well, I am not the Minister, so let us allow the Minister to answer. If not, I could have told you that reading the Answer, the question you are posing is not based on the Answer, but the Minister is there to clarify.

Mr Nikpe: Thank you, Mr Speaker. They are saying you have given me a clue as to what to say, but if the Hon

Member had listened to me very well, he would have understood. When we talk of Metro Mass Transit Limited, they have seen some improvement in their daily activities. For instance, last year, a monthly collection of about GH¢8 million was what they had. From 2025 to date, we have seen improvement to about GH¢14 million. Based on that, we are able to negotiate with vendors to supply us buses that we can now be paying them or servicing them on some agreed basis.

However, we are not here to predict what the Budget would contain when we come to the Metro Mass Transit Limited. So the Hon Member would have to wait and see how it goes. If the Hon Member wants, he could put in another Question so I come and clarify how we are procuring the buses.

The Speaker: Yes, it is now your turn.

Dr Mahama: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. The Hon Minister in his answer stated, and I quote:

“... the current operational fleet of Metro Mass Transit Ltd. (MMTL), comprising approximately 134 buses, presents significant challenges in sustaining operational costs and expanding services”.

Mr Speaker, the emphasis here is “sustaining operational costs and expanding services”. I would want to find out from the Hon Minister, if in the light of this part of the Answer, there are provisions because of the issue of electric buses. We do know that the Ministry introduced such an initiative

last year, or part of the last administration, to curb the operational costs aspects of the operation of Metro Mass Transit. Is the Minister considering that as part of the new buses they are going to procure, in a way of addressing the operational costs and expanding service challenges, as highlighted in the Answer? Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Nikpe: Thank you, Mr Speaker. This is going to be a mixture of the Electric Vehicles (EVs) and the engine buses. The Hon Member must remember that as a country, we are not yet developed with the infrastructure for electronics. Once we are building the infrastructure, we still have to rely on the engine vehicles alongside. So, this supply will have some EVs alongside the engine vehicles. Thank you.

The Speaker: Yes, the last supplementary question.

Nana Asafo-Adjei Ayeh: Thank you, Mr Speaker. I just want to seek a simple clarification and ask the Hon Minister if we have a dedicated source of funding for the 134 buses. Thank you.

The Speaker: You mentioned 134 buses but maybe you got the number wrong because the 134 is what is already in operation. —

Nana Ayeh: Mr Speaker, he said: “acquired 500 new buses”.

The Speaker: Even though he was not specific, he said approximately 134. I find it very difficult to understand, but you have not asked that question. I do not know why he was approximating 134 but

he said “approximately 134” but it is the 500 new buses they are yet to procure.

Nana Ayeh: Thank you for your guidance, Mr Speaker. It is the 500 buses and I am seeking to ask the Hon Minister the source of funding for these new buses the Government seeks to procure. Thank you.

Mr Nikpe: Mr Speaker, I mentioned that we are having a special arrangement with some vendors with whom we will establish a payment system between Metro Mass and our vendors. I said that our revenue generation has improved and based on the improvement we have made in the revenue collection, they have confidence that when they partner with us, we would be able to pay them as the arrangement will be. So, it is a special vehicle arrangement between the Ministry of Transport, the Metro Mass Transit Limited and some three vendors who are going to supply the buses to us. We will manage them together and ensure that we set aside an account for all the proceeds to be able to service their interests. Thank you.

The Speaker: Hon Members, we move on to the next Question numbered 322, which stands in the name of the Hon Member for Suame, Mr John Darko. Hon Member, you may ask your Question now?

Update on the Proposal of Government to set up a National Airline

Mr John Darko (NPP — Suame): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Transport to provide an update on the

proposal of Government to set up a national airline

Minister for Transport (Mr Joseph Bukari Nikpe) (MP): Mr Speaker, H.E. John Dramani Mahama reaffirmed Government's commitment to restart a transparent process for the establishment of a national airline during the State of the Nation Address. In line with this vision, I inaugurated a Task Force on 7th May, 2025 to oversee and coordinate all necessary activities towards the realisation of this national objective.

4:38 p.m.

Mr Speaker, I am pleased to inform this august House that the task force has made significant progress. A business model and operational framework to guide Government's engagement with potential strategic partners for the establishment of the national airline has been submitted to the Office of the President.

Mr Speaker, the establishment of a national airline is a matter of strategic national importance. It is more than just restoring an airline. It is about establishing Ghana as a vital aviation hub in the sub-region, promoting tourism, creating jobs and opening up new avenues for economic progress.

Mr Speaker, the Ministry of Transport remains fully committed to ensuring that the process is undertaken with professionalism, transparency and physical responsibility.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

The Speaker: Hon Member, any supplementary questions?

Mr Darko: Yes, Mr Speaker.

I want to find out from the Hon Minister if he can update us on whether he has received any proposals from any potential investors since the President announced this policy. If he has, is he able to tell this House who these potential investors are?

Mr Bukari: Mr Speaker, the Question was for me to update this House with the progress that Government has made so far on the proposal, and I have said that we established a task force that has submitted the business model and an operational framework to guide us in engaging our investors. So, it is too early for me to start naming the investors who have submitted proposals to us. But I can tell you that this business model will guide us to engage with those who have presented their proposals to partner with Government to establish a national air carrier.

Thank you.

The Speaker: In essence, you have received some proposals—

Mr Darko: Have you or have you not?

The Speaker: Sorry, I was trying to clarify it for maybe a further supplementary question but if you are in such a haste, I would allow you to bring—Because the Answer was very pregnant and I want to deliver some of the—Maybe twins or quadruplets.

[Laughter] From the Minister's Answer, it shows that some proposals have been received but he is reluctant to name those who have submitted the proposals. Am I right, Hon Minister?

Mr Bukari: Mr Speaker, that is right.

The Speaker: Hon Member, any supplementary question?

Mr Darko: Mr Speaker, I would have thought that the people's representative would be willing to share this very important information with the people of Ghana if they have received any such proposals. The people of Ghana would like to know who the people are but if he is telling us that he cannot tell us now, we hope that in the future he would give us that information.

Mr Speaker, is the Hon Minister able to tell the people of Ghana, in his estimation, when it is likely for us to see our flag in the sky?

Mr Bukari: Mr Speaker, establishing a national airline involves a lot. After the collapse of the Ghana Airways, we have attempted so many times to revive it but failed. We are guided by it and for that matter we are taking the processes seriously. We established a task force which has submitted a business model and an operational framework which we are supposed to use to engage all the proposals we have received from the private sector. We cannot jump the gun when we have not met with them. We have not yet assessed their capacities or efficiency in delivering on the timelines that would be fixed.

So, we will update you at every stage in terms of when and how we are going to roll out the national air carrier.

The Speaker: Hon Member, you are done with your three supplementary questions.

Mr Darko: Yes, Mr Speaker, thank you very much.

Nana Agyei Baffour Awuah: Mr Speaker, I heard the Hon Minister say that they have received proposals from the private sector. Mr Speaker, respectfully, would the Hon Minister be kind enough to disclose to us what the proposals entail? Is it in respect of ownership or operations? Is it the case that it is in the area of ownership or operations that they are looking at partnering the private sector?

The Speaker: Well, he is now going to the specifics. You know the Question talked about proposal of Government. Now, you have also received some proposals from private sector and he wants to know what the proposals entail.

Mr Bukari: Mr Speaker, we are looking at a PPP model and Government would not want to have so much control over the public-private partnership arrangement we are having. However, I said that this business model is what is to guide us going forward. So, I think that we will use the model and assess all the proposals that are brought to us to be able to determine the level which Government's participation would be in the air carrier or how much shares Government would have in the proposed air carrier.

So, I would want to say that we will use the business model to guide us going forward in the selection of a business model which will be communicated to you. Thank you.

Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

I would like to reference paragraph 2 of the Hon Minister's Answer to Question 322, where he talked about a task force having provided a framework to guide Government's engagement with potential strategic partner for the establishment of the national airline. However, in subsequent follow-ups, the Hon Minister is saying that they have received some proposals.

My question is, what went into the receipt of the proposals? Because in the Answer, he talked about a strategic partner. Now, he is saying they have moved to receive proposals. Is it possible for him to share that business model they have received with this House? Because we have not seen any publication about Government opening up proposals for competitive tendering in any airline in this country, yet Government has already received proposals. So, I think the Hon Minister needs to come clear on this. This is a House of records.

4:48 p.m.

When did Government open up for businesses to submit proposals and what is the Government's take in making sure that the people of Ghana are served with adequate information on the model and the proposals that the Ministry has received?

Mr Speaker, thank you very much.

The Speaker: Hon Members, the Question itself is not too clear. The Question is to ask the Minister for Transport to provide an update on the proposal of Government to set up a national airline. But the reference is to a declaration of intention by Government to set up an airline, not a proposal. So, when you say an update on the proposal, it means there is already a proposal of Government. But what you referred to is a declaration of intent. Just like how Ghanaians always say we gained our independence on 6th March, 1957. No, that was the day that there was a declaration. We did not gain it that day because we were still under the Queen of England. So, we were not independent and still had a Governor-General. In fact, it changed from Governor to Governor-General and all our laws – it is not the same – all our laws were still assented to by the Queen.

We only had a Prime Minister, Head of Government, but we were not independent until 1st July, 1960. That is when we attained our real freedom and independence and we became independent to make laws by our own selves, assented to by our President. It is the same as the declaration of independence in the United States of America in 1776. But it took them almost a year before they gained their independence and became united, which was around 1868. That is a long time.

So, when you say that Government's declaration of intent has now turned to proposal of Government and you are looking for update on that proposal, you

are putting something on nothing. Yes, Hon Nana Asafo Adjei-Ayeh?

Nana Asafo Adjei-Ayeh: Mr Speaker, thank you, for your guidance and education, we are grateful.

Mr Speaker, I seek your guidance again. We are now looking at the answer that was given by the Minister, which is captured here, and also the follow-ups that the Minister has given to the House. That is what we are asking and seeking clarification on.

Mr Speaker, for example, which the Minister has mentioned that there is a business proposal. Now, we seek to ask that, is the ownership or partnership all operational? That is what we seek to ask.

Mr Speaker, it is not with our question, but it is with the follow-up and the answers that have been given by the Minister.

I thank you.

The Speaker: Hon Members, I went through the Answer and we would realise that in the written Answer, the Minister did not refer to proposal. He only said;

“H.E. John Dramani Mahama reaffirmed Government’s commitment to restart a transparent process for the establishment of a National Airline during the State of the Nation Address. In line with this vision, I inaugurated a Task Force on 7th May 2025 to oversee and coordinate all necessary activities towards the realization of this national objective.”

Then, the rest follow. So, there is no proposal in the Answer.

Mr Darko: Mr Speaker, if I may assist —

The Speaker: Your follow-up question solicited an answer from him which referred to a proposal from private sector.

Mr Darko: Mr Speaker, with respect you say that there is something fundamentally wrong with my Question, but I was very clear in my mind when I posed the Question the way I did, because what is the meaning of proposal? Any dictionary will explain that proposal means a plan or a suggestion. So, there is nothing wrong with the Question at all. I was very clear in my mind when I put the Question that way and the Minister did not see anything wrong with it, that is why he came here and sought to answer. The various questions coming in are as a result of the answers he gave.

Mr Speaker, absolutely, there is nothing wrong with the Question, because proposals include plans and suggestions. We know the President announced that in this House and that is why I felt the need to ask for an update, that is the point. There is nothing wrong.

Mr Speaker, with respect I was very clear in my mind, when I asked the Question.

The Speaker: So, could you tell us the Government proposal, since you were clear? You were asking for an update on a proposal. So, can you tell us

that proposal that you are looking for the update on, since you were clear in your mind?

Mr Darko: Mr Speaker, the President had told this House that he intends to set up —

The Speaker: Exactly.

Mr Darko: Mr Speaker, proposals include suggestions and the Minister did not see anything wrong with it. He came here to answer the Question — *[Uproar]*

Mr Speaker, with respect, I do not think that it is wrong to say proposal because the President came here and made that promise to the people of Ghana.

The Speaker: Hon Member, your attention is being drawn to the Rules. It is my duty to guide the House in all that you do. So, when I go through and I see that there is a problem, I try to guide by coming with my understanding, based on not just language, but experience and application of the Rules that we have been using for some time now. I am surprised to hear you say that a suggestion is a proposal. But, when you spoke again, you were not looking at it as a suggestion. You were saying an intention. These are technical terms and not just ordinary English and you expect that somebody would be guided to provide an answer.

So, when you talk about an update on a proposal in connection with an intention that has been declared, it means at least some things have been put

together to guide and you are now trying to see how that is being implemented. That is why you are asking for updates.

So, I raised it based on that and I am just trying to draw attention to the fact that in some of these questions, you need the guidance of the technical people so that you can achieve your aim. So, I do not need any fight with you because we are not competitors at all — *[Uproar]*

Mr Darko: Mr Speaker, thank you very much.

The Speaker: Hon Members, I realised that the Minister, in trying to answer the Question, also raised a lot of red herrings and agitated the minds of Members. So, they started asking so many questions, trying to extract something from the Minister who is unwilling to give that information out.

4:58p.m.

But you have already let the cat out of the bag. So, are you prepared to respond to the last question?

Mr Bukari: Mr Speaker, I was clear with the response I gave. He wanted updates on proposals of Government to set up a national airline, and I said that we have established a task force and they have submitted an operational framework to guide Government in its engagement with potential or strategic investors. He then wanted to know whether we received some proposals, and I said, yes. For the Government to announce that we are establishing a national airline, some people, out of their interest, have submitted proposals which are not yet considered. I also said it was too early for

me to begin to talk of proposals that we have not considered. So, it is not that the proposals have been looked at or worked on and we are not relaying it. I am only giving an additional information that people have expressed interest in partnering Government or doing business with Government to establish a national airline. But the task force has given us a business model that we are going to use to look through all that we have been receiving from other private sector investors. So, the proposals as we have received, are not yet proposals we have worked or agreed on; they are just people showing their interest in partnering with Government. So, they are not yet considered to be called proposals. The Hon Member's Question was for me to show him Government proposals, and that was why I mentioned and added that information. Thank you, Mr Speaker.

The Speaker: Hon Minister, in the spirit of your own Answer, which is very clear in the first sentence, and communicators are here—plenty of communicators, you said that “H.E. John Mahama reaffirmed Government's commitment to restart a transparent process...” So, if that process is transparent, why are you holding back?

Mr Bukari: Mr Speaker, we have not got to looking at the proposals, and that is why we cannot discuss them. But I was responding to the question that asked of the proposal to establish a national airline, of which I said; one, there would be the task force; two, there would be a business model; and three, there would be an operational framework to guide us look into the proposal.

So, we have not got there yet.

Mr Ayariga — *rose* —

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Member? Let me first hear from at least one of your Members before I come to you, Hon Majority Leader.

Mr Mohammed Adamu Ramadan: Mr Speaker, when the task force was inaugurated on the 7th May, 2025, among its terms of reference were to develop a robust and sustainable business plan, meticulous coordination and potential strategic and technical partners, rigorous oversight of all necessary regulatory and certification processes, and the crucial groundwork for initial operationalisation, including recruitment, fleet acquisition strategies, and route network development. I would want to find out from the Hon Minister that, now that the business model has been sent to the Office of the President, are the task force still at work or are they waiting for feedback from the Office of the President so that they proceed with the remaining terms of reference?

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Bukari: Mr Speaker, the task force is not dissolved. They are to guide us in having an operational framework and engagement with potential strategic partners for the establishment of the national airline. So, they are not dissolved; we are still working with them, and they are guiding the way to select a strategic partner.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Nana Agyei Baffour Awuah (NPP — Manhyia South): Mr Speaker, the Hon Minister mentioned receipt of proposals. How did the persons who sent their proposals know the Ministry was receiving proposals in respect of this business? In the light of transparency, how did they know they were receiving proposals?

The Speaker: That is why I started by talking about update on proposals, which was the Question, and so we wanted to get that, but now, you turned the proposal to the private sector, not Government. Can you answer?

Mr Bukari: Mr Speaker, I mentioned that we were going to use a transparent way of establishing a national airline, and we have stages at which when we get to, we will be able to account to our people. In response to why or how people knew and brought proposals, these are business people, and every day, Government receives proposal from people or interested parties to do business. I added the information that even though we are at this stage of having a business model, we have had the private sector coming in with their proposals. But at this stage, we just received them, but we have not yet looked at them. So, it is an additional information that I gave to the House and not to say that I will be questioning them on why they brought their proposal, and ask them to take it away because we have not got to the stage of receiving proposals; no. Our responsibility is to ensure that we have a transparent system of establishing a national airline. So, if one brings a proposal tomorrow, I will receive it. But with the time when it will

be looked at, we are not there yet. I am not sure I can turn any Ghanaian or business person away from expressing interest in partnering with Government to establish a national airline.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, what I heard the Hon Minister say is that proposals are being made to Government, but Government wants to define a business model to determine how to choose a strategic partner. There are several business models and we could have a situation where an existing airline decides to adopt all the routes of Ghana and fly the National Flag, and there could also be other alternative business models. So, unless one has decided on a business model, one cannot really decide the strategic partner to partner with? So, is it the case that the Hon Minister is still at the point of determining the business model?

Mr Bukari: Mr Speaker, the task force has submitted a business model which we are using to determine which strategic investor to partner with.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Francis Kwabena Berepong Owusu-Akyaw: Mr Speaker, the Hon Minister in his answer said that he received some proposals. I would want to know how many proposals have been received? Also, how many are from Ghanaians and how many are from foreigners?

Mr Bukari: Mr Speaker, I believe I said that we have received proposals, but we have not looked at them. We are not yet there, and that question was asked and I said the same thing.

5:08 p.m.

Yes, we have received proposals, but we have not gotten to the point of going through them to know what is contained in those proposals.

The Speaker: Hon Members, we have so many Questions. I think that clearly, the message has gotten to all of us that the Government has not gotten to a stage where it has a proposal. It is just because of the intention that has been declared, others are now submitting proposals. According to him, they are putting a transparent system in place to guide the Government as to how to even go about looking at the proposals that they are receiving. And that will be guided by the Government's own policy. Even though he referred to Public Private Partnership (PPP) as the choice that is being looked at, maybe at the end of the day, the determination will be made. Let us take it as that. Hon Members are still encouraged to go further into this matter by asking additional Questions at a later date. After reading the *Official Report* of today, you will see how you can rephrase some other Questions to bring him back because he is here to answer Questions and is always available to do so. So, I want to plead with Members so that we can proceed to the other Questions that are for today.

Please, with that assurance from those who were asking the Questions, we

will proceed to the Question numbered 175, which is from the Member of Parliament for Odododiodioo, Mr Alfred Nii Kotey Ashie. Please, you may ask your Question now.

Sorry, I did not realise it was that we are moving away from the Ministry of Transport to the Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs.

On behalf of the House, I want to thank you so much for attending upon the House and doing all you can to respond to our Questions. You will come back again; I am sure they will bring you back. Thank you so much for coming.

Let us go on to the next Minister, the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs.

We will start with the Question numbered 175, which stands in the name of Hon Alfred Nii Kotey Ashie, Member of Parliament for Odododiodioo.

MINISTRY OF LOCAL GOVERNMENT, CHIEFTAINCY AND RELIGIOUS AFFAIRS.

Support for Traders and Market Associations Affected by Fire Outbreaks

Mr Alfred Nii Kotey Ashie (NDC—Odododiodioo): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs, the support the Government is providing to traders and market associations affected by frequent fire outbreaks in the Timber Market, Makola and Kantamanto markets.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs (Mr Ahmed Ibrahim): Mr Speaker, the welfare of traders in these markets has always been of paramount concern to Government, given their contribution to commerce, employment and revenue generation. Consequently, whenever fire incidents occur in these markets, the Government responds swiftly and decisively to support affected traders and restore normalcy.

Mr Speaker, after the fires were contained, the Accra Metropolitan Assembly (AMA) coordinated post-disaster recovery efforts, including the removal of debris and restoration of access routes to facilitate reconstruction and safe trading activities.

Mr Speaker, in further demonstration of the Government's commitment to the welfare of these traders, H.E. President John Dramani Mahama made a financial donation of GH¢1,000,000.00 to support the reconstruction and redevelopment of the Kantamanto Market. The Accra Metropolitan Assembly also complemented this effort with an additional contribution of funding support to the affected traders.

Additionally, the AMA is engaging the traders and market associations to explore the various support options available.

Mr Speaker, regarding the Timber Market, the Government again acted through the Accra Metropolitan Assembly to undertake a demarcation and lane-

creation exercise within the market. This initiative was aimed at improving accessibility for emergency response vehicles, particularly fire tenders, and at preventing the spread of future fires.

Similarly, the AMA is engaging traders and market associations to explore possible options of support for them to enhance their trade. As a control measure, the AMA continues to collaborate with the Ghana National Fire Service, the National Disaster Management Organisation (NADMO), and market associations to intensify fire safety education, risk assessments, and regular inspection of electrical installations in all major markets, including Makola.

Mr Speaker, these interventions underscore the Government's unwavering commitment to safeguarding lives, livelihoods, and property, and to ensuring that our markets remain safe, resilient, and vibrant centres of economic activity for the people of Ghana.

Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

The Speaker: Hon Member, any supplementary question?

Mr Ashie: Mr Speaker, I must say I am grateful to His Excellency the President for the intervention put in place to ensure that market traders are taken care of. Thank you, I am grateful.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Member?

Mr John Darko: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

In the Minister's Answer to the House, he mentioned, and I quote, "... H.E. President John Dramani Mahama made a financial donation of GH¢1 million to support the reconstruction...". Now, Mr Speaker, I want to find out from the Minister whether this GH¢ 1 million donation is from the Government or from the President himself. Thank you very much.

The Speaker: Yes, Minister?

Mr Ibrahim: Mr Speaker, the President of the Republic donated GH¢1 million for redevelopment and reconstruction, and that money is being implemented by the Accra Metropolitan Assembly. That is, to the best of my knowledge.

The Speaker: Hon Member, you are not satisfied with the answer?

Mr Darko: With respect, Mr Speaker, the question really was whether it was from his personal funds or from the Government. The Minister's answer does not do justice to the question.

The Speaker: That is what he has. Because you do not want him to say something that he does not know. Do you understand? Maybe if His Excellency were here, we would have asked him whether the money was his personal funds or from the Government. But from his point of view, this was what came to his knowledge, and that was what he has shared with you. You may not be satisfied or happy, but that is what he has. So we cannot go beyond that.

Please. Next supplementary question. The gentleman in the red tie.

Nana Asafo-Adjei Ayeh: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, I want to find out from the Minister whether the intention of the GH¢1 million given to the market women is to be used to construct a market. Because my understanding is that markets are constructed by governments. So, is the Government going to construct the market, or are the market women supposed to use the GH¢1 million to construct the market? Thank you.

The Speaker: You forced me to come in. He did not say that the money was given to the market women. The answer is clear there. So why are you bringing in the market women here? He said it was made to support the reconstruction and redevelopment. He did not say to whom it was made.

Nana Ayeh: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, your guidance is clear, but my point still holds that if it is made to support the reconstruction and redevelopment of the Kantamanto market, is it to support them to reconstruct it, or it is the amount of money supposed to be used to reconstruct the market by the Government? Mr Speaker, that is the point I would want to know from the Hon Minister.

The Speaker: The Minister even told you who took possession of that money and what that body is doing with the money. It is in the Answer of the Minister. He mentioned the Assembly and said they are using the money to do one, two and three.

Please, next supplementary.

Alhaji Nurideen Muhammed Mumuni: Mr Speaker, thank you very much.

If you look at the Answer given by the Minister, after mentioning the GH¢1 million support by the Government,

5:18 p.m.

He went further to say that the Accra Metropolitan Assembly (AMA) also contributed some funding to support the traders. I want to find out from the Minister how much contribution they made to support the traders.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Ibrahim: Mr Speaker, I am unable to give the exact amount the AMA has given in support of that because they are not only giving cash. When given time, I can let them collate everything and the House will be served with that.

The Speaker: Yes.

Mr Baffour Awuah: Mr Speaker, respectfully, when you look at the Answer of the Hon Minister, he says the support by Government is GH¢1 million and the AMA is also complementing that support with an additional contribution of funding support to the affected traders. The question is, who is in charge of the reconstruction and redevelopment of the market? Is it Government or the affected traders? Whom are these supports going to for the purposes of reconstruction and redevelopment? Is it government or the affected traders?

Mr Chairman: They want to know who this support is going to.

Mr Ibrahim: Mr Speaker, I think as MPs we are better placed to appreciate the Answer. When they say support is given, it means that is not the total amount that will be used to construct the thing. By the nature of the market that we are talking of, woods are being purchased to start the construction. Affected people may not have the amount to be able to do it immediately. It is not in the Government's budget. There is no contract for that. As MPs, what we sometimes do when those things happen is that we buy some of the building materials and donate for the reconstruction to start. If you look at Timber market, the way it happens, government will have to support so that the traders themselves—When it is burned today, by tomorrow, they will start reconstruction. That is where they earn their livelihood.

What government does is to for instance, support with GH¢1 million. They can use the GH¢1 million to buy woods and support it with their personal resources to start reconstruction'. It is not like a contract is awarded and the AMA is supervising the market. Mr Speaker, that is not it. The AMA itself has the responsibility to construct a 24-hour market for the indigenes. Every Metropolitan, Municipal and District Assembly is to engage in construction of their market. That has been budgeted for. But this is a disaster that has occurred and a relief is being given. When relief is being given as MPs normally do, I think, Mr Speaker, we are better placed to

appreciate it, which I think my Colleague better appreciates than the questions he is asking me to answer.

The Speaker: Hon Minister, they just want to know who that support went to. Who was given that support; was it given to the market women or the AMA?

Mr Ibrahim: Mr Speaker, the Government donated through the AMA to the market associations, and all the market associations and the traders have been mentioned here.

The Speaker: Very clear. Yes, the last person. We will move on to other Questions, so please.

I have been very generous.

Mr Anthony Mmieh: Hon Minister, I believe the demarcation and lane creation affected the size of the land after the exercise. Were there any traders who were affected, and if any were affected, is there anything the government is doing to accommodate them in terms of finding an alternate accommodation for them? Thank you.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister.

Mr Ibrahim: Mr Speaker, I think the question that was asked was about government support and the support that government has given is what I have stated here. If there are further Government supports in the course of time, I will let the House know.

Some Hon Members — *rose* —

The Speaker: Hon Members, you want to stay here till midnight? If you want to continue, I will allow you.

Alhaji Mumuni: Thank you very much. Mr Speaker, I want to find out from the Minister what is being done to make sure that the fire does not reoccur in the market now that it is being built by the market people themselves.

The Speaker: Yes, Minister?

Mr Ibrahim: Mr Speaker, in the Answer, I stated that the AMA itself is doing re-demarcation of lanes to ensure easy accessibility of utility service providers in case of any fire outbreak. Careful measures are being implemented, and you know when it comes to this, we are on top.

The Speaker: Hon Members, let us take the next Question. The Question numbered 277 stands in the name of the Hon Member for Manso-Nkwanta, Mr Tweneboa Kodua Fokuo.

Yes?

Mr Matthew Nyindam: Mr Speaker, I was on my feet, but unfortunately, I did not catch your eye early. Could I ask my question?

The Speaker: Yes, what is it on?

Mr Nyindam: It is to further ask a question before you move to the next question; I have a question to ask.

The Speaker: I was very clear about the supplementary questions. I said that was the last supplementary question.

Mr Nyindam: I thought maybe you would give some priority to the Frontbench. You normally do that.

The Speaker: I did not know that you were part of the Frontbench.

Mr Nyindam: Mr Chairman, for now I am holding the fort. When the Leaders are not available, the available Leaders take over. So, I have taken over.

The Speaker: Is there any *coup d'état*?

Mr Nyindam: In a very peaceful manner.

The Speaker: You are not part of the Leaders to be available Leader. If you were part of the Leadership of the Minority group, if the Leader is not there and the deputy is not there, whoever is there is the available Leader. But you are not part of the Leadership of the Minority group, so you cannot be the available Leader.

Mr Nyindam: Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the education. This is the first time I am hearing this, that if you are not part of the Leadership, you cannot be an available Leader. Today is the first time. I will urge Hon Members to be guided. You should be guided because this is a very important education.

Mr Speaker, I am not available Leader. I am here to stand in for the Leadership.

The Speaker: The Hon Member wants to enjoy the liberties of

Leadership. I will not question the source of your authority. I will not question it because I believe that without prompting, you will not catapult yourself to that high class of Leadership. So, I will give you the opportunity to ask your supplementary question.

Mr Nyindam: Mr Speaker, thank you for indulging me.

Mr Speaker, if you look at the Question that was asked about the support of government to the traders, and if you look at the Minister's response, he started with the GHC1 million donation by H.E. John Dramani Mahama. So can I conclude that since the Question has to do with the support from Government and he mentioned the GHC1 million donation from the President, I can conclude that that money is coming from the State but not him personally. Can I conclude that way, Mr Speaker? That is my question to the Hon Minister.

The Speaker: Hon Available Leader or standing in Leader—*[Laughter]*—You know the Rules. You do not introduce debate into a Question.

5:28 p.m.

That is what you are doing now.

Mr Nyindam: I started by looking at the Question which has to do with support from Government to the traders, which is where the Answer comes from.

The Speaker: Yes.

Mr Nyindam: I remember an Hon Colleague found out from the Hon

Minister whether the GH¢1 million was from the President himself or it was from the state, and that question was, in a way, overruled because the President is not here to answer it. So, I am just looking at the Answer and the Question, whether I can infer by saying, that since the GH¢1 million was mentioned to answer Government support, can we conclude that, since we are running an Executive Presidency, the President donated that money to traders on behalf of the state? Whether this was right or wrong, that is what I want to get from the Hon Minister. So, I am not debating it.

The Speaker: Well, that is the point, I have taken it. Because as you sit here, if you go to the market yourself and make a donation to support whatever is going on there, one cannot jump on to say that donation you have made is on behalf of the New Patriotic Party (NPP) or on behalf of the Minority Caucus in Parliament. You should understand that. It could be personal, from the Caucus or from any source. This is because the Hon Minister did not disclose this. He only said it was given to the A.M.A.; he was clear on that one. But whether it was personal or it was from Government, he did not tell us.

Mr Nyindam: I cannot debate the Speaker, so I leave it here.

The Speaker: Thank you so much. I want us to proceed on to the next Questions. We have so many Questions today. The Question numbered 277 stands in the name of the Hon Member for Manso Nkwanta.

Status of Construction of Six-Unit Classroom Blocks at Yawhemekrom and Essuowim under IPEP in Manso Nkwanta Constituency

Mr Tweneboa Kodua Fokuo (NPP — Manso Nkwanta): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs the status of the construction of the 1 No.6-unit classroom block at Yawhemekrom and 1 No.6-unit classroom block at Essuowim under the Infrastructure for Poverty Eradication Programme (IPEP) in the Manso Nkwanta Constituency.

Mr Ibrahim: Mr Speaker, under the Infrastructure for Poverty Eradication Programme (IPEP), the erstwhile Ministry for Special Development Initiative, through the Middle Belt Development Authority (MBDA), in December, 2024, awarded contracts for the construction of 1 No. 6-unit classroom block each at Essuowim and Yawhemekrom respectively, in the Amansie West District Assembly.

I wish to indicate that these projects, though awarded during the last days of the previous administration, as clearly indicated in the Authority's Hand Over Notes, could not commence. My recent checks from the Assembly indicates a 0 per cent completion level.

Mr Speaker, you will agree with me that these are 'legacy' projects inherited by the Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs following the realignment by H.E. the

President of the Republic in January, 2025. Accordingly, the Ministry initiated the process to take nationwide inventory of all such on-going projects for completion by the various Metropolitan, Municipal and District Assemblies (MMDAs).

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Member, any supplementary question?

Mr Fokuo: Mr Speaker. I would want to find out from the Hon Minister — I have a copy of the contract here, and that contradicts the date of the award that the Hon Minister gave, as December, 2024. What I have is 22nd April, 2024 from a copy of the contract. So, if the Minister could clarify that. *[Interruption]* No, what I have is a copy of the contract, which was given to the contractor. It indicates that it was awarded on 22nd April, 2024, and not December, 2024, as he indicated. So, I need clarity.

The Speaker: Sorry, my attention was diverted. I did not even hear the supplementary question. Hon Minister, did you hear what he said?

Mr Ibrahim: Mr Speaker, yes,

The Speaker: Please, he is providing the answer.

Mr Ibrahim: By the handing-over notes given to me, the contract was awarded in December, 2024. My Hon Colleague on the opposite Side is saying it was April, 2024. The handing-over notes say that it was December, 2024, and at zero completion rate, but he is saying it is April, 2024; at what completion rate? So, Mr Speaker, for the

sake of accountability, I would want my Hon Colleague to assist me, because the project must be completed. So, he should give me the contract document that he has and I will go and cross-check with the handing over note. This is because I did not prepare the handing over note.

Those who awarded the contract are those who gave me the handing over note and that is the Middle Belt Development Authority. So, if there are discrepancies, somebody must be held responsible. I need his document to cross-check with mine. I also need further clarification between him and I. It is his Constituency and I must support him to complete it, so he should let us work together. What is the completion rate? Is it still zero? If it is zero, why would they award the contract in April through to December but with zero completion rate? We need to do something about it. So, I would need his document for that.

Mr Fokuo: Mr Speaker, I am ready to reconcile the document I have with me with that of the Hon Minister. In terms of the completion rate, I would need to have a discussion with him. This is because, as we speak, in one of the two towns, which is Yawhemekrom, I have seen a three-unit classroom block done. The shell structure is completed at the same spot that was given to this contractor. So, I would want to understand if it is a different contract that has been awarded to a new contractor or who has built this three-unit? This is because he is telling me it is at zero completion rate. As we speak, there is a three-unit classroom shell built there. So, I think there is some reconciliation that we need to do on this.

Thank you.

The Speaker: Well, Hon Member, the question you asked talked about a six-unit classroom block, it never mentioned a three-unit classroom block. Now, you are talking about a three-unit classroom block that has been constructed, but your question talked about one No.6-unit classroom block at Yawhemekrom, and one No.6-unit classroom block at Essuowin.

Mr Fokuo: Mr Speaker, the reason I brought about this three-unit classroom block is that it is the same piece of land that was awarded to the contractor to construct the six-unit classroom block, but now, one would find a three-unit classroom block on the same piece of land. The Hon Minister has told the whole House that completion rate is zero.

5.38 p.m.

I would want to understand where the three-unit classroom block construction is coming from if the completion rate is zero. Mr Speaker, that is the question I would want to ask the Minister.

Thank you.

The Speaker: Please meet the Minister and try to reconcile it. So far as the six-unit is concerned, nothing has been started, but there is a three-unit there so you have to go and reconcile.

We will move on to the next Question, Question number 278. It stands in the name of the same the Member of Parliament for Manso Nkwanta.

Status of Construction of AstroTurf Football Pitch at Pakyi No. 1

Mr Tweneboa Kodua Fokuo (NPP — Manso Nkwanta): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs the status of the ongoing AstroTurf football pitch construction at Pakyi No. 1 in the Manso Nkwanta Constituency.

The Speaker: Yes, Minister?

Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs (Mr Ahmed Ibrahim): Mr Speaker, similarly, the on-going AstroTurf football pitch at Pakyi No. 1 was being constructed by the Middle Belt Development Authority under the Infrastructure for Poverty Eradication Programme (IPEP) in the Amansie West District prior to the change of government in January 2025.

Mr Speaker, my checks from the Amansie West District Assembly indicate that the AstroTurf football pitch project was inherited by the District Assembly at 55 per cent completion rate but currently advanced to 85 per cent pursuant to the provisions made in the 2025 District Assemblies Common Fund (DACF) Utilisation Guidelines for legacy projects. It is expected that the Assembly will consider the completion of the AstroTurf project in due course.

The Speaker: Hon Member, any supplementary question?

Mr Fokuo: Mr Speaker, yes.

Hon Minister, thank you for the update. I would want to have an idea of

the works that have been done by the contractor of which Interim Payment Certificates (IPCs) have been raised and when he should expect some payments, because he is owed a lot and it is not enabling him to continue the project as he would wish. So, if I can get some responses from the Minister.

Thank you.

The Speaker: Well, you want to talk about payment? Yes, Minister if you want to?

Mr Ibrahim: Mr Speaker, as I said, the project has been handed over to the District Assembly to take over, and progress has been moved from 55 per cent to 85 per cent by my checks from them. So, if the Hon Colleague is asking of the payment, the IPCs pending contracts sum amount paid to them, I think I may have to revert to the Assembly for further clarification. Thank you.

The Hon Member and I have to work together to make sure we bring finality to the issue.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Fokuo: Mr Speaker, thank you. Hon Minister, I thank you for your responses. I am happy. Right from here we can reconcile some of these.

My last supplementary question is, Mr Minister, the stadium AstroTurf is coming up well, although some payments are delayed. There is no stand around it. When one sees it, there is nowhere for spectators to sit. Would the

Minister consider varying the contract to include at least some stands for spectators? Thank you.

The Speaker: Yes, Minister?

Mr Ibrahim: Mr Speaker, clearly, all those AstroTurfs are going to be community-owned, therefore, they must be community-supported. That is why we have termed them as legacy projects. When that project is completed, the people will be using it. That is why 20 per cent of the DACF money given to them must be spent on those legacy projects.

As a Government, we do not want to abandon any project by our predecessor. That is why Government has given that directive. So, clearly, if there is a need for variation to do improvement, the Hon Member for that area, the District Chief Executive (DCE) for that area and I must discuss it. Once they write to me for variation to do other things, we will consider it on merit and proceed accordingly.

Thank you, my Brother.

The Speaker: Hon Members, let us move to the next Question. I thought you have finished.

Mr Fokuo: Mr Speaker, if you will permit me to make a point.

The Speaker: All right.

Mr Fokuo: Mr Speaker, I want to thank the Minister once again. I believe my DCE is watching us, and I believe he is going to take the instruction, as the

Minister has said, that he should be taking over more or less for us to move towards completing this project. So, I will work with the DCE and the Minister to see how we would carry this project forward.

I thank you very much.

The Speaker: Hon Members, we now move on to the Question numbered 309. It stands in the name of the Hon Member for Kwadaso. The next three Questions all stand in the name of Hon Member for Kwadaso, Prof Kingsley Nyarko.

**Absorption of Development
Authorities Staff into District
Assemblies under the 2025 Budget**

Prof Kingsley Nyarko (NPP — Kwadaso): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs the total number of staff that were in the employ of the development authorities and the number that have been absorbed into the district assemblies as indicated in the 2025 budget.

The Speaker: Yes, Minister?

Mr Ibrahim: Mr Speaker, the total staff strength of the development authorities were 142 as at June 2025. The breakdown is as follows: Coastal Development Authority (CODA) – 41 officers, Middle Belt Development Authority (MBDA) – 53 officers, and Northern Development Authority (NDA) – 48 officers; stationed in Accra, Kumasi, and Tamale, respectively, as

well as satellite offices in Sunyani and Koforidua.

Mr Speaker, considering the processes and procedures for integration into the local government service, the Ministry has constituted a team to facilitate and liaise with the Office of the Head of Local Government Service to absorb the staff of the development authorities into the service to be stationed at the beneficiary district assemblies to support implementation of the Infrastructure for Poverty Eradication Programme (IPEP) projects.

The Speaker: Any supplementary question?

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker I thank the Hon Minister for the answer provided. However, I think the second part of my question was not addressed. I wanted to know the number that has been engaged by the district assemblies. But nothing was said to that effect. So, I would like to know from him, out of the 142 indicated, have they all been absorbed? Are they working with assemblies? How many are working in assemblies? That is what I want to know.

Mr Speaker, thank you.

The Speaker: Yes, Minister?

Mr Ibrahim: Mr Speaker, absorbing the staff of the Ministry of Special Development Initiatives or the development authorities into the Local Government Service is not as simple as that. I am saying this because out of these 153, most of them were already in the Local Government Service where the

salaries are low. They were sent on secondment to the development authorities, and were given three or four times of those salaries. So, if you are bringing them back to their former positions, there are legal implications. That is why a committee has been formed to make sure that they go into the salary processes and the absorption processes to make sure that we are able to do the transition smoothly.

Mr Speaker, currently, I am being asked questions under their jurisdiction. Assuming we had done the absorption without taking cognisance of the inventory of all the projects which are over 3,000 projects across the country, we would send them and some of the projects will be abandoned because there would be no records of them.

So, we are not just absorbing them. We are taking inventory of the project, making sure that—CODA has 2,000 projects uncompleted. MBDA has about 1,500 projects uncompleted. NDA also has so-and-so projects not completed. When we have the inventory, we have the staff, their conditions of service—Because the conditions of service of the development authorities are higher than conditions of service of the Local Government Service. So, you need representatives from the Office of the Attorney General and Ministry of Justice, Public Service Commission and the Local Government Service. It must be a coordinated effort. And when that is done, my good Brother, Prof Kingsley Nyarko, will appreciate it. Without doing that—Even from January to date, they are being paid because they are taking all those inventory and work is going on. So,

it is not like we have abandoned them or we have sacked them. We have written to the Office of the Attorney General and Ministry of Justice to make sure that those Acts that established them are also repealed, so that the Acts will not be there. But as I speak to you, work is being done.

So, if the Hon Member asks me how many of the 153 have been absorbed, my good Prof, we have 37,000 staff in the Local Government Service. We have only 153 in the Development Authorities and their conditions of service were about four or five times. Even though they were sent on secondment to work there, bringing them back is not as simple as that. These are some of the challenges we are facing and do not let us trivialise it. But careful, strategic human resource management must go on, which we are embarking upon. Thank you for the opportunity.

5:48 p.m.

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, with respect to my respected Leader and Hon Minister, he knows I admire him a lot. With all that he said, the question was not answered—*[Laughter]*—I just need a specific answer from the Hon Minister. How many have been absorbed? Or in other words, we would like to know where the 142 are at the moment. Thank you, Mr Speaker.

The Speaker: Yes, Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, my Brother, Prof Nyarko knows that we do not have to be argumentative in our

Questions, especially the supplementary. The Hon Member may not like the Answer, but that is the answer. He can rephrase in his subsequent supplementary. The Hon Member needs time to go and do some other business so leave the commentaries and ask the questions, so that we can bring Question time to an end. I am pleading with him. Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, I do not think I am litigating this matter. Mr Speaker is very experienced, and he himself knows that the question is not answered. I wanted to find out the number, but of all that the Hon Minister said, he could not tell us the number that was employed. So, my understanding is that these persons are probably in their homes. Mr Speaker, the Minister should let us know the numbers since the Minister assumed office about eight or nine months ago. So please, he should let us know the number. This is a simple question and a harmless one. Thank you, Mr Speaker.

The Speaker: Hon Member, the Question imputes something. This is because it says that:

“To ask the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs the total number of staff that were in the employ of the Development Authorities, and the number that have been absorbed into the District Assemblies as indicated in the 2025 Budget.”

So, we were given the number that were in the employ of the development authorities and the Answer shows that

they are still where they are and they are still being paid the conditions of service they were being paid. Because to absorb, which meant that they will have to change their status, you have to do human resource management, which the Minister referred to as a strategic human resource management. That is not yet done and that is why you need the multi-sectoral sort of committee to handle that.

So, what I understood the Minister to have said is that, they are still where they are. Nothing has happened to them, and they are still receiving the same salaries. Only that with the places they are — not all, because I know the Northern Development Authority still exists. And so, they have not changed their positions, and that they are still receiving the same salary and that is what he said.

Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Mahama Ayariga: Mr Speaker, understandably so, because these were offices established by specific statutes and Government announced a policy of abolishing those organisations. Bills have to be brought to this House to repeal them and then when they are repealed, in the repealing legislation, the issue of how to transit the existing workforce will be catered for. So, I can understand why the Minister is only engaged in preparatory work towards a transition. But he can only transit them if this Parliament passes the Bills repealing them, and then provides some guidance by legislation on what to do with the existing workforce.

The Speaker: Yes, do you want to ask a supplementary question?

Mr Nyindam: Mr Speaker, so I want to find out from the Minister if these staff are home and being paid for no work done? I just want an answer from the Minister.

Mr A. Ibrahim: Mr Speaker, I would not have gotten an answer like this if they were still not in office. They are still working. Even if a public officer is being audited, he or she must be paid. So, we are taking inventory and they are supporting us to do that inventory. If the Hon Member wants Coastal Development, they are where they are and we need them to bring information on issues. We are doing proper internal auditing. In all these, they are cooperating with us to be able to do it. Other than that, if one just goes by an Executive fiat or by Ministerial word of mouth, like we did to the road tolls, there would be chaos. As a Minister, I just cannot tell all of them to go home because we are abolishing the authorities. I cannot sack them to go home. So, clearly, they are receiving salaries and they are supporting us in the auditing and the inventory processes—*[Interruption]* So, they are working.

I am not a lawyer. I know constitutionally, a person cannot vary the conditions of service of a public office to their disadvantage. At the Local Government, they were paid GH¢4,000 and GH¢2,000. Then when they made them development authorities, it was multiplied by three and four. Now, they tell them to go back to the Local Government Service. As a Minister, can I reduce it back to the GH¢4,000 they were taking? So, there are strategic

decisions to be taken and all of us need to work together.

It is not just enough to come and say I am a Minister among others. The Attorney-General has a representative in the committee and he is advising on how to take the legislative processes to repeal the Act. All these are part of their terms of reference. And I have written to the Majority Leader that we will be bringing proposals for the House to legislate and repeal those laws. They are in the custody and it is part of the agenda for Parliament for this Meeting.

Mr Speaker, so some serious work is taking place. This may not be the first time that such transitioning is happening. I know we have seniors with that expertise who will support us to be able to do that. On that note, I thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Mr Nyindam: Mr Speaker, our Standing Order gives every Member here, with the exception of Leadership, the opportunity to ask at least two supplementary questions. This is the second one so, I am not assuming the position of an available Leader, please.

Mr Speaker, I have listened to the Minister's answers. We were all in this House when a Statement was made that the Authorities have all been collapsed and all the works have been transferred to the various MMDCEs and we are all aware of that. So, as we speak, there is no assigned work to any Authority because all works have been deployed back to the MMDCEs. This is the Statement that was made.

5:58 p.m.

Now, a question was asked and in answering, the Minister said there is a difficulty in absorbing the people because of the way they have been migrated or their salaries have been increased. So, you would have a challenge bringing them back. The Minister made that statement on this Floor and said he is not a lawyer. I am also not a lawyer. He has also admitted that he cannot vary their benefits to their disadvantage.

Now the question is, if he knows he cannot vary their salaries to their disadvantage, what then is the difficulty in absorbing them into the system? That is my question. Because whatever auditing they are going to do, these people are legally employed, so they cannot sack them.

The Speaker: Yes, Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, it is inaccurate for the Hon Member for Kpandai, Mr Nyindam, to say categorically that a statement was made on this Floor, that the Coastal and the Middle Development Authorities have been collapsed and the workforce have been—*[Interruption]* No, the Hon Majority Leader said that there was a policy decision that the two authorities—In fact, the intention is to maintain the Northern Development Authority, but the Middle and the Coastal Development Authorities will be collapsed. But he knows that this House must be engaged to enact another law to repeal the two existing legislations. It is the processes that have been explained to him, so he cannot categorically say that those two

authorities have been collapsed and their workforce hived off to another agency and he does not know what is happening.

The Hon Minister is trying to explain that it is a transitional process; audit is happening; project sites are being determined. So, let us set the record straight on this matter. By all means, he can ask his question, but let it reflect the fact.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Ibrahim: Mr Speaker, because of the transition, what the stand in Leader failed to recognise was that he was part of this House which passed the Budget for 2025, including the salaries of those officers, and that is what is being used to pay them.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Members, let us move on to the last Question which again stands in the name of the Member of Parliament for Kwadaso. Hon Member, you may ask the Question.

Prof Nyarko: Yes, Mr Speaker, it is the last but one Question, so I am now going to ask—

The Speaker: It is the last but one?

Prof Nyarko: Yes, Mr Speaker. I have two outstanding Questions.

The Speaker: You have not asked the one on shrines?

Prof Nyarko: Yes, Mr Speaker.

The Speaker: Wow!

Prof Nyarko: This Question is very important to me.

Number of Shrines in the Country and their Registration Status

Prof Kingsley Nyarko (NPP — Kwadaso): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy, and Religious Affairs the total number of shrines in the country and the number of them that are registered. Thank you.

Mr Ibrahim: Mr Speaker, thank you very much. My Brother from Deeper Christian Life Ministry is asking us to count the shrines.

The Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs currently, has no concrete records on the total number of shrines in the country. We will consider liaising with traditional authorities and include Prof Kingsley Nyarko to take stock of all shrines in the country in the very near future. Thank you.

The Speaker: Hon Member, can you assist us with the definition of a shrine? Because I find it difficult to understand what a shrine means.

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, I asked three separate Questions. One of them was to find out about the number of shrines, another about the number of churches and the third about the number of mosques in the country for a purpose. All these three Questions were admitted. I am surprised that only the one on shrines was programmed. *[Laughter]* Because my understanding is that we need to have that data.

Mr Speaker, I was laying a foundation before I respond to your question. We have the traditional religion in this country and that is where they worship their deities. So, it is incumbent on state institutions to ensure that we know the number of shrines, churches and mosques for policy decisions and directions. I asked this Question purposefully because if we live in a society without knowing the number of these institutions, then it means we are making a mistake. That is the epicentre of my Question.

The Hon Minister's response to my Question was that they do not have the data. My follow up question would have been to ask him what he would do to ensure that we have data on the number of shrines in this country. That is why I asked this Question, Mr Speaker.

The Speaker: Hon Member, you realised that I said you were left with the last Question. And when you said it is the last but one, I asked whether you wanted to ask the Question on shrines—*[Laughter]*—and you said, yes. Well, I realised that you were going into unknown waters, and it is dangerous to swim in unknown waters. Now, you decided to swim in it.

You know you are not part of the culture of worshipping in shrines. A shrine is variously described. You are talking about stools; there are families; there are individuals. So, when you talk about the number of shrines in the country, it is an impossibility. I thought you have realised that maybe the one who programmed the Question was trying to play a trick on you, because you said the other Questions were not

programmed. They limited it to only the one on shrines. It does not talk about those on mosques and churches.

Now it will be very difficult for the Hon Minister to know the number of shrines in the country.

Yes, Majority Leader.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I want to ask the Hon Minister whether he thinks the New Patriotic Party (NPP) is looking for shrines—*[Laughter]*

The Speaker: Prof Nyarko, the Hon Majority Leader is out of order. *[Laughter]* He is completely out of order.

6:08 p.m.

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, I hope the Leader of the House, who is very much respected, is not in any way trivialising the import and impact of this Question. I thought deeply before asking that Question, because he is a Minister who is trying to—

The Speaker: Prof, please, you are also out of order. May we proceed to the next Question, and let us discuss the other one outside the Plenary session. So, please, we move on to the Question numbered 311.

Hon Members, please, this is not a matter for the House alone. It is a national issue, so what you have said so far is sufficient. Let us move on to the next Question, and then know how to handle these matters. Sometimes, they are very sensitive matters that we do not joke about.

So, please, may we move on to the next Question? If you do not want guidance, I will allow you, because I do not want to gag any Member. Express your views, and you will be assessed accordingly by Ghanaians. So, anybody who wants to continue, I will allow them. Yes?

Dr Fred Kyei Asamoah: Mr Speaker thank you.

I would like to ask the Minister if there is any legal protection for victims of the shrine? Because I know Article 21 (1) (c) of the 1992 Constitution allows for freedom of religion and practice. So, I would like to know whether there is any legal protection for victims of traditional shrines. Because we have heard about the money doubling, putting money in the pocket, and all sorts of things that are going on.

So, I want to know from the Hon Minister if there is any legal protection for such victims.

The Speaker: I thought I had drawn the attention of the House to the fact that it is a good guide for me that we are entering into unknown waters and it is not advisable to swim into unknown waters. So, let us leave it there. There is still a lot of work to be done in that area so you would need some clarity on to how to phrase your Questions. This one you have phrased, if I allow the conversation, it can raise a lot of issues that may touch other people, our own people, who are not part of this discussion.

So, please, let us leave it as it is and then move on to the last Question. Hon Member, you may ask your last Question.

Measures to Promote and Deepen Religious Tolerance and Inclusivity

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy, and Religious Affairs, the measures the Ministry has implemented to promote and deepen religious tolerance and inclusivity in the country.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Ibrahim: Mr Speaker, following the realignment of the Ministry to include the erstwhile Ministry of Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs in January 2025, and upon my assumption of office, we have embarked on a series of reforms and rolled out strategic activities aimed at strengthening and deepening religious cohesion, tolerance, and inclusivity in the country.

Among these are:

1. Engagement with the leadership of religious bodies and groups.
2. Participating in their anniversaries and meetings to address issues of unity and to encourage co-existence.
3. Introduction of the National Prayer and Thanksgiving Day to foster religious tolerance.
4. Constituted the Ministerial Advisory Board of the Ministry

with membership from the leadership of the different faiths,

5. Regional engagements to address succession issues and other leadership altercations, and paying courtesy calls periodically to various religious leaders to dialogue on issues of tolerance.

Mr Speaker, the draft policy on Religion has also been revised to include activities on tolerance and inclusivity.

Additionally, inter and intra-faith conflicts have been addressed at the Ministerial level and, where needful, referred to the appropriate religious body for redress.

Mr Speaker, thank you, for the opportunity.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Member, any supplementary?

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, the Minister, in his response, indicated that they are in the process of working on a revised policy on religion, which is at the drafting stage. I would like to know when it will be finalised.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Ibrahim: Mr Speaker, I will be meeting the Committee on 6th November, so I am unable to give the timelines. But when I meet them, and after briefing me, I will be well-positioned to give the accurate timelines in order for me not to mislead this august House.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Member?

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, my last question is that, looking at the measures taken so far, I have seen some progress being made. But I want to find out from the Hon Minister if it is appropriate for the Ministry to consider also engaging not only the religious actors, but also outside the religious bracket. For example, the academia and Civil Society Organisations (CSOs). How can we engage them to champion the acceptance and promotion of religious tolerance and inclusivity? Because if we leave it for only those within the religious space, they might not do much.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Ibrahim: Mr Speaker, it is good advice, which is well-taken. Prof Kingsley Nyarko is a very good Friend who has been very helpful to the Ministry, so it is well-taken. And thank you for the advice.

The Speaker: It is also important for me to add that even in this House, we have freedom of religious beliefs and practice and we have been holding meetings. We have been led by the African Centre for Parliamentary Affairs (ACEPA). We have even got a regional organisation, and we have been holding workshops and conferences on it.

Ghana is seen as a lead in this matter. In fact, there is some funding support, and some Members of Parliament here have been attending those workshops in other countries. Because they are learning from the shining example of this country, where we have been able to live

together in peace and stability, in spite of the numerous religious beliefs in the country. So those of you who want to join that group, are at liberty to do so. There is funding for it. We have held a number of workshops here in Ghana. We have received Members of Parliament from sister African countries to deliberate on this topic we are talking about.

That is why I was drawing your attention to the issue of the shrine because it is something that is being discussed, and we know how sensitive that thing is. Much work has to be done, as you said, with research and all those things. So Civil Society Organisations and think tanks are involved, and we are working together on this matter. I thank you for your understanding.

You want more supplementary questions? All right.

Dr Abdul Kabiru Tiah Mahama: Mr Speaker, thank you very much.

Mr Speaker, I have a supplementary question on religious tolerance and inclusivity. The President appointed a presidential staffer for prophecies, Elvis Afriyie Ankrah.

The Speaker: I do not know whether you have evidence of the appointment. Because I am not aware of any official communication to this House from His Excellency the President. But if you have, you are at liberty to go on.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, I am sure the Presidency is still to come up with a list of presidential staffers in accordance

with the laws of the country. And when that comes, we will be able to proceed. But we know presidential staffers have been appointed, and we are also reading in the news that one of those appointed for religious prophecy is Elvis Afriyie Ankrah.

6:18 p.m.

Mr Speaker, the question I would like to put to the Hon Minister is that, how do we reconcile? Because I see that move by the President in light of religious tolerance and inclusivity, but how do we align that with that of fake prophecies in a country where a lot of fake prophecies are causing fear and panic. What is the fine line the Ministry is drawing between these fake prophecies and religious tolerance in the country? This is my question to the Hon Minister.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Majority Leader.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, you tried to assist the Hon Member for Walewale to reframe his question, but he persisted in misrepresenting information by saying that the President appointed a presidential staffer for religious prophecies. That clearly is not true. There is a staffer assigned with responsibility for Diaspora Relations and Religious Affairs, but there is no staffer responsible for prophecies. I think that he should retract that and continue with his question. I think this is very important.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Member?

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, I am sure what the Hon Leader of the House is saying is no different from what I am

saying because when he reads the full title of that appointment—The full title of that appointment is here. It is “Presidential Envoy for Interfaith and Ecumenical Relations”. Mr Speaker, that was the long title of the appointment. Simply put, and for the want of a simpler expression, the envoy responsible for prophecies. In fact, he mentioned that he is to receive all prophecies and that after some time, he was complaining that the prophecies were now too many for him to collect. This is a matter of public record; I am not making this up. The person appointed stated that he was receiving too many prophecies and that the prophecies should stop; they should prophesy about development and not death. The Hon Leader of the House is saying I am misrepresenting—Unless of course, what I am presenting is not what is out there.

The Speaker: Well, Hon Member, what you are referring to is a matter of public discourse. However, we are looking at evidence, evidence that you can rely on as legal. That is what we are looking at. You said that they have submitted the list of presidential staffers. I was going to read from that list that somebody has been appointed. You used a different language. Now you are reading another phraseology which somebody has just sourced from his mobile phone, which is different from what you earlier stated. You see, we cannot only depend on public discourse and ask questions. You should have done some background check to know what the letter of appointment actually stated and then you base on it to ask your question.

Ghanaians are listening, and they are interested in this. However, I thought that as a good Muslim, it is in the Holy Quran, stated clearly as to what what is happening is about. It is there. It is in the Holy Quran and it is also in the Holy Bible about prophecies, and that the time will come, you are going to have so many of them. — [**Mr Boamah-Nyarko:** Surah 105] — I do not know whether it is Surah 105 or not. The Speaker shall not be misled. [*Laughter*]

Hon Members, let us leave it at that. I think the person who asked the question is satisfied, and I cannot even see him in the House again. Please, it has been a very long day and I have been presiding for more than four hours now. I do not think that it is healthy for me. So, with your indulgence, we may try and put finishing touches by some concluding information before we adjourn the Sitting.

I will on your behalf thank the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs for attending upon the House and answering satisfactorily the questions that have been raised by Members. We thank you for coming.

Yes, Senior Member of Parliament?

Alhaji Collins Dauda: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, and thank you for the indulgence. I rise to make an observation regarding how we conduct ourselves when the Speaker is addressing the House. During the Question time today, the Hon Member for Kpandai, Mr Matthew Nyindam, while asking a question and you tried to

guide him, kept standing while you were addressing the House. The same was also exhibited by the Hon Member for Manso-Nkwanta, Mr Tweneboa Kodua Fokuo. I thought that this matter must be made clear so that we are all obliged.

Accordingly, Mr Speaker, I refer to Standing Order 126 (2), which reads as follows, and with your permission I beg to quote:

“(2) Whenever the Speaker addresses the House, any Member standing shall immediately resume the Member’s seat, and the Speaker shall be heard in silence.”

Mr Speaker, this is the observation I have made, and I thought that I should make it clear in order that we do not abuse the Standing Orders. I thank you very much for your indulgence.

The Speaker: Thank you so much. That is the longest-serving Member of Parliament in Ghana.

Hon Members, on this matter, we have always provided, annually, the opportunity for Caucuses to hold workshops. I expect Leaders to lead their Members to go into the details of these Standing Orders, particularly the ethics, etiquettes, and the language, which we refer to as Parliamentary language. However, it looks like that is not being done.

6:28 p.m.

The basics that we take you through during orientation are not sufficient to mould you into a professional Member

of Parliament. It has been difficult, but the Speakers are hesitant to try to exercise some powers because we need to work to build consensus; that is why we do not go hard on you. But it is important that you take time off to go through these things. This is because you will be going to other countries to participate in conferences and other things, and they observe you a lot as you get up to put across your points of view on the matters that are being discussed. Body language, the words you use and how you dress, all count in making you an Hon Member of Parliament. So, it is an important issue he has raised.

There are more, I have observed. When the Speaker, for example, is addressing the House, no Member of Parliament is expected to get up and walk out of the Plenary session, but that has been the common thing here. Particularly when Members are engaged in conversations and the Speaker is drawing their attention, and it is like it is nobody's business. It does not work properly, because even though we are trying to get our system here to go according to the rules and guidelines for airing the proceedings of the House, we have not yet got it right. So, Hon Members should be very careful because all these are used to assess you for the next elections; it is not just what you come to tell them. The Members watching and particularly now that we have our own dedicated television (TV) station, it is important for you to change.

And please, nobody comes into Parliament just to stay for only four years. Unless those who come and get so

disappointed, they want to go back. This is because some may think that here is better, but when they come in, they realise that what they have been reading in the papers is not what actually takes place here. So, they get disappointed and decide, voluntarily, not to contest again, and that has added to the high attrition rate of Members in the House. So, it is an important point; a very cogent one. I thank you so much for drawing the attention of the House and Members. Without much ado —Deputy Whip, sorry, you were Deputy Whip before.

Mr Nyindam: Mr Speaker, once a leader, always a leader.

The Speaker: I understand now.

Mr Nyindam: Because my name was mentioned, I am grateful you gave me the opportunity to have a word. Obviously, I will not debate my Uncle, who happens to be one of the longest serving Members of Parliament, who is preparing to exit this House very soon. I have taken his counsel and cue of whatever he said and I duly want to thank him for that observation. Just like you have rightly said, these are things that we all have to take note of.

Mr Speaker, I thought your intervention was going to be short, so I stood up, but when I realised that it was going to take some time, I took my seat. This is because I was once a Deputy Whip and I know some of these rules, so I would definitely be the last person to violate them. But just as he said, I agree with him and I do not think such will repeat from my side. It is a good advice

to all of us. Mr Speaker, I am grateful for the opportunity.

The Speaker: I am not sure the Hon Member is preparing to exit, because the longest serving Member of Parliament in the world is Sir Winston Churchill, and he was in Parliament for over 50 years, so he is just starting. He is now getting to about 29 years then he will end up at 32 years. No, he is still too young. We expect him to go more. You know that in the United Kingdom, if you ask for the best Prime Minister, they will cite Sir Winston Churchill. So please, let us encourage Members to be career Members of Parliament, so that we can all be motivated to work even better than what they have done and to be guided by whatever they do. Do not discourage people from staying long in the House; that is not correct. With this, I will proceed to adjourn the House.

Mr Mahama Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I am wondering if, because tomorrow is Friday, we would sit earlier in the day or we should maintain our 2:00 p.m. Sitting time. On Fridays, Members may want to start travelling early enough, so could we sit in the early part of the day? Mr Speaker, your two Deputies are not immediately available, so —

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Member, I was just raising the issue of when to commence Sitting tomorrow, because

tomorrow is Friday. Do we start early, 10 o'clock in the forenoon, or 2 p.m. in the afternoon? Yes, please?

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib: Mr Speaker, I would not have opposed the submission by the Leader of Government Business, save that I think you have a programme at 10 o'clock. I am sure that we considered the time that we are going to start tomorrow at 2:00 p.m., and that was the reason we put the programme at 10:00 a.m. But that is subject to your further directions. I am sure we are minded to start at 10:00 a.m.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Members, my attention has been drawn to an important meeting with our partners from the Inter-Parliamentary Union (IPU) tomorrow morning, and myself and Leadership are expected to be part of it. My two Deputies are not available. Both of them are on assignments, so if I have to be part of this meeting, the only option is for us to start in the afternoon.

So, I will proceed to adjourn the House to tomorrow, Friday at 2:00 p.m. in the afternoon. The House is accordingly adjourned.

ADJOURNMENT

The House was adjourned at 6.38 p.m. till Friday, 31st October, 2025 at 2:00 p.m.

